MODULE 2: GRAMMAR
(CO: 3)

Complete Study Textbook, Professional Writing Guide & VIT FAT Question Bank

Aligned with Official VIT BAENG101 Course Page Syllabus, Question Bank, and Past FAT Papers

Scope of This Textbook (Official VIT Syllabus - All 9 Topics): (1) Concord (Subject-Verb Agreement) - Part 1, (2) Concord - Part 2, (3) Concord - Part 3, (4) Tense shifts - Part 1, (5) Tense shifts - Part 2, (6) Tense shifts - Part 3, (7) Conditionals, (8) Active and Passive Voice - Part 1, and (9) Active and Passive Voice - Part 2.

1 VIT FAT Exam Blueprint & Master Rules

Module 2 carries **20 marks** in BAENG101 FAT:

1. **Subject-Verb Concord (5 to 10 Marks):** Identifying and correcting subject-verb agreement errors across complex sentences with intervening prepositional phrases, compound subjects, and collective nouns.
2. **Conditionals & Tense Consistency (5 to 10 Marks):** Zero, First, Second, Third, and Mixed conditionals; correcting unwarranted tense shifts in scientific abstracts.
3. **Active vs. Passive Voice Conversion (5 to 10 Marks):** Converting procedural steps into impersonal passive voice ('The mixture was heated to 100° C' instead of 'We heated the mixture').

Grammar Rule	Standard Principle	Exam Trap & Correction
Concord: Intervening Phrase	Subject determines verb, NOT the intervening noun.	'A pack of wolves **is** (not are) roaming.' 'The quality of the sensors **is** high.'
Concord: Correlative Pairs	Verb agrees with the CLOSER subject in **either...or**, **neither...nor**.	'Neither the engineer nor the **technicians were** present.'
Conditional: Zero	If + Present Simple → Present Simple (Universal physical laws).	'If water reaches 100° C, it boils.'
Conditional: First	If + Present Simple → will + Bare Infinitive (Probable future).	'If the server load exceeds 90%, the alarm will trigger.'
Conditional: Second	If + Past Simple → would + Bare Infinitive (Hypothetical/unreal).	'If we had a quantum computer, we would decrypt it instantly.'
Conditional: Third	If + Past Perfect → would have + Past Participle (Impossible past).	'If the backup battery had engaged, data loss would have been avoided.'

2 Subject-Verb Concord & Scientific Voice

2.1 Concord Golden Rules

1. **Collective Nouns:** Singular when acting as a unified unit (**The committee has decided**); plural when individual members act separately (**The jury were divided in their opinions**).
2. **Expressions of Quantity:** When referring to a single total sum, distance, or time duration, use a singular verb (**Ten thousand dollars is an expensive component**; **Five kilometers is within walking range**).
3. **Each / Every / Either:** Always take singular verbs (**Each of the semiconductor wafers has been tested**).

2.2 Impersonal Passive in Technical Reporting

Technical writing prioritizes the action and experimental result over the researcher. Active voice emphasizes the actor (**We calibrated the spectrometer**), whereas scientific impersonal passive foregrounds objective reality: **The spectrometer was calibrated using high-purity argon gas**.